

He paused.
Today, the words have changed but the pride has not.”

Zayd looked at him. “What do you mean?”

“Now, people sometimes hide their boasting inside stories of struggle.”

Khalid’s voice became softer.

“They say, my father was never there for me...yet I still became more successful than you.”

“I grew up with nothing, yet I achieved more than everyone else.”

“I suffered more than you, so I deserve to stand above you.”

“Their pain may be real. Their struggles may be real.

“But somewhere along the way...the story stops being about gratitude.

“It becomes a throne.”

Zayd remained quiet.

“They no longer tell the story to give others hope,” Khalid said.

“They tell it to prove that they are greater. They believe hardship automatically makes them better than those who suffered differently...or those whose struggles they cannot see.”